Best Mental Health Apps: Top Apps for Anxiety, Stress, Sleep, Mood & Therapy

Taking care of your mental health can be challenging when everyday responsibilities, work, relationships, financial pressure, poor sleep, and other sources of stress begin to affect how you feel. Fortunately, smartphones have made it easier to access tools that can support everyday mental wellness. From guided meditation and breathing exercises to mood tracking, journaling, sleep support, and online therapy, there are now many mental health apps designed for different needs.

The challenge is choosing an app that actually matches what you are looking for. Some apps are built primarily for meditation and relaxation, while others focus on anxiety, depression, sleep, self-care, or habit building. Online therapy apps take another approach by connecting users with licensed mental health professionals. There are also prescription digital therapeutics that are different from ordinary wellness apps and may be regulated by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration.

In this guide, we look at some of the best mental health apps, what they offer, who may find them useful, and what you should consider before entering personal information into any mental wellness application. Whether you are looking for the best app for anxiety, a meditation app, a mood tracker, an online therapy platform, or a free mental health app, this guide can help you understand your options.



Important: Mental health apps can be useful tools for self-care and support, but they are not automatically a replacement for professional mental health treatment. If you are experiencing an immediate mental health emergency or believe you may hurt yourself or someone else, seek emergency assistance. In the U.S., you can also call or text 988 to reach the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. The service is free and confidential.

What Are Mental Health Apps?

Mental health apps are mobile or web-based applications that provide tools, information, exercises, or services related to psychological well-being and emotional health.

The term mental health app covers a very wide range of products. A simple meditation application and a platform that connects you with a licensed therapist are both digital mental health tools, but they are not designed to provide the same type of support.

Common types of mental health apps include:

- Meditation and mindfulness apps

- Anxiety and stress management apps
- Mood tracking apps
- Journaling apps
- Sleep and relaxation apps
- Self-care and habit-building apps
- CBT-based self-help apps
- Online therapy apps
- Psychiatry and medication-management platforms
- Prescription digital therapeutics

The American Psychological Association explains that consumer wellness apps can focus on areas such as meditation, journaling, gratitude, habit tracking, and general well-being. These are different from digital therapeutics, which use clinically validated interventions to treat or prevent specific health conditions and can fall under FDA oversight.

That distinction is important because downloading an app from an app store does not automatically mean that the application has been clinically tested, FDA-cleared, or covered by HIPAA.

Best Mental Health Apps

1. Headspace

Headspace is one of the most recognizable names in the mental wellness space. It started with a strong focus on meditation and mindfulness and has expanded into sleep, stress management, mental health resources, and professional care.

The app provides guided meditation sessions, mindfulness exercises, sleep content, focus tools, and other resources designed to help users build healthier daily routines. Headspace currently promotes more than 1,000 meditations and other resources covering areas such as sleep, stress management, and everyday mental wellness.

For someone searching for the best meditation app, best mindfulness app, or a convenient way to practice relaxation every day, Headspace can be a useful option to explore.

One feature that makes the platform particularly interesting is its expansion into online therapy. Headspace currently offers therapy to adults in the U.S. and connects eligible users with licensed therapists. Insurance eligibility can be checked during enrollment, and the company also offers out-of-pocket options.

This gives users the option of combining self-guided wellness content with professional support when appropriate.

Headspace features include:

- Guided meditation
- Mindfulness exercises
- Sleep resources

- Stress-management content
- Breathing exercises
- Focus tools
- Mental wellness programs
- AI-based support features
- Online therapy for eligible users

2. Calm

Calm is another popular app for meditation, relaxation, mindfulness, and sleep.

It is particularly well known for guided meditation and sleep-oriented content. People who have trouble switching off at night may find its relaxation exercises, sleep stories, sounds, and bedtime resources useful as part of a regular nighttime routine.

Calm can also be relevant for people searching for mental health apps for stress, meditation apps for anxiety, sleep apps, or general self-care tools.

It is important to understand that using a meditation app is different from receiving therapy. Meditation and relaxation exercises can be part of a healthy wellness routine, but they should not be assumed to treat a diagnosed mental health condition simply because the app discusses anxiety, depression, or stress.

3. BetterHelp

BetterHelp is designed around online counseling rather than meditation or mood tracking.

The platform connects users with licensed therapists, making it an option for people who specifically want professional mental health support through an online service. BetterHelp's provider requirements include a valid state-issued clinical license and professional credentials.

Online therapy can be convenient for people who prefer communicating from home or who have difficulty attending traditional appointments.

Depending on the platform, location, provider availability, and payment arrangement, users may have access to different communication formats and types of counseling.

If your search is specifically for an online therapy app, therapy app for anxiety, or online counseling platform, this type of service is more relevant than a general meditation application.

4. Talkspace

Talkspace is another major digital platform for professional mental health services.

Unlike a basic meditation or self-care app, Talkspace provides access to licensed providers for services such as therapy and psychiatry. Its provider directory allows users in the United States to search based on state, specialty, and insurance information. Because mental health professionals must be licensed where they practice, the user's state of residence is an important part of the matching process.

This makes Talkspace particularly relevant for people who are looking for online therapy, virtual counseling, or access to a mental health professional without relying entirely on self-guided exercises.

When considering any therapy platform, check whether your insurance plan is accepted, what type of provider you are being matched with, what services are included, and how appointments are conducted.

5. Finch

Finch takes a more playful approach to mental wellness and self-care.

Instead of presenting itself like a traditional clinical platform, Finch uses a virtual-pet concept to encourage users to complete everyday self-care activities. This approach can make activities such as journaling, breathing exercises, goal setting, and daily check-ins feel more approachable.

Finch can be particularly interesting for people who want a self-care app or a tool that encourages healthy routines without making every interaction feel clinical.

The app can also appeal to users who have difficulty maintaining habits. Rather than attempting to make major changes overnight, users can focus on smaller daily activities and gradually build consistency.

6. Daylio

Daylio is a popular type of mood tracking app that allows users to record their moods and connect them with daily activities.

Mood tracking can help people identify patterns in their everyday routines. For example, after consistently recording your mood, you may notice relationships between how you feel and factors such as sleep, exercise, workload, social activity, or daily routines.

A mood tracker should not be considered a diagnostic tool. Instead, it can serve as a personal record that helps you reflect on your emotional patterns.

It may also provide useful information to discuss with a mental health professional if you decide that additional support is necessary.

7. Moodfit

Moodfit is another option for people interested in tracking and improving different aspects of their mental wellness.

Apps in this category can combine mood tracking with activities such as mindfulness, breathing exercises, journaling, goal setting, and other self-care tools.

The advantage of a broader mental wellness app is that users can experiment with different strategies rather than relying on a single activity.

For someone searching for mental health apps for stress, mood tracker apps, or self-care apps for adults, an app with several types of tools may be worth considering.

8. Insight Timer

Insight Timer is best known for meditation and mindfulness content and offers a large collection of guided practices.

It can be useful for people who want to experiment with different meditation styles instead of following a single structured program.

Users interested in mindfulness may find content related to relaxation, breathing, sleep, stress, focus, and meditation.

As with other meditation applications, it is best viewed as a wellness resource rather than a substitute for clinical treatment.

9. PTSD Coach

PTSD Coach is a different kind of mental health application. It was developed by the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs and is designed specifically around PTSD-related education and coping tools.

Rather than functioning like a general wellness application, PTSD Coach focuses on information and exercises related to post-traumatic stress.

It can be especially relevant for veterans and other people dealing with PTSD symptoms, although anyone considering it should understand what the app is designed to provide and when professional treatment may be necessary.

10. NOCD

NOCD focuses specifically on obsessive-compulsive disorder.

This makes it different from general mental wellness apps. Instead of trying to cover every aspect of mental health, specialized services can focus on a particular condition and the type of treatment commonly used for it.

For people searching for an OCD therapy app or online OCD treatment resources, a specialized platform may be more relevant than a general meditation or self-care app.

Anyone dealing with significant OCD symptoms should consider professional assessment rather than relying solely on an app.

Prescription Digital Therapeutics Are Different

Not every mental health app belongs in the same category.

Some products are designed to provide general wellness resources, while others are developed as digital therapeutics intended to treat specific medical conditions.

The American Psychological Association explains that digital therapeutics can deliver evidence-based and clinically validated interventions for mental and behavioral health disorders. These products may require an order or prescription and can be regulated by the FDA as software medical devices.

Examples discussed by the APA include DaylightRX, an anxiety-focused digital therapeutic, and Rejoyn, a prescription digital therapeutic for depression symptoms.

Rejoyn, for example, is designed for adults 22 and older with major depressive disorder who are taking antidepressant medication. The company describes it as an FDA-authorized prescription app that provides six weeks of brain-training exercises and skills-based therapy lessons.

These products should not be confused with ordinary meditation or wellness apps. Their regulatory status, intended use, clinical evidence, and method of access can be substantially different.

Best Mental Health Apps for Anxiety

If anxiety is your primary concern, there are several types of apps to consider.

Meditation and breathing apps may help with relaxation and present-moment awareness. CBT-based applications may provide structured exercises around thoughts and behaviors. Therapy platforms can provide access to licensed professionals.

For occasional everyday stress or nervousness, a meditation or breathing application may be a convenient first step.

For persistent anxiety that interferes with work, relationships, sleep, school, or everyday activities, professional evaluation may be more appropriate.

Some digital therapeutics are specifically designed for anxiety disorders. The APA notes that FDA-regulated digital therapeutics have been developed for conditions including generalized anxiety disorder.

Best Mental Health Apps for Depression

Depression is another area where it is important to distinguish between wellness and treatment.

Mood trackers, journaling tools, meditation apps, and self-care applications may help users monitor how they are feeling and maintain healthy routines. However, these tools should not automatically be considered treatment for clinical depression.

There are also prescription digital therapeutics specifically designed around depression. Rejoyn, for example, is an FDA-authorized prescription app intended as an add-on to antidepressant medication for adults with major depressive disorder.

If symptoms such as persistent sadness, loss of interest, hopelessness, major changes in sleep or appetite, or difficulty functioning continue, speaking with a qualified healthcare professional is important.

Best Mental Health Apps for Stress

Stress is one of the most common reasons people turn to wellness applications.

A good stress-management app may provide:

- Guided breathing
- Meditation
- Relaxation exercises
- Journaling
- Mindfulness
- Sleep resources
- Habit tracking
- Short daily exercises

Apps such as Headspace and Calm are commonly associated with these types of features.

The best option is often the one that fits naturally into your routine. A five-minute exercise that you use regularly may be more practical than an elaborate program that you rarely open.

Best Mental Health Apps for Sleep

Sleep and mental health are closely connected, which is why many mental wellness applications include sleep resources.

Sleep-focused apps may offer:

- Guided sleep meditations
- Breathing exercises
- Sleep stories
- Relaxing sounds
- Bedtime routines
- Sleep tracking
- Wind-down exercises

For occasional difficulty relaxing at bedtime, these tools can be part of a healthy nighttime routine.

However, persistent insomnia may require professional assessment. The digital therapeutic category also includes FDA-cleared treatments for chronic insomnia. The APA has highlighted SleepioRx as an example of an FDA-cleared digital intervention for chronic insomnia.

Free Mental Health Apps

Many people search for free mental health apps because subscription prices can add up quickly.

Free options may include:

- Basic meditation apps
- Mood trackers
- Journaling apps
- Breathing tools
- Self-care applications
- Public-sector mental health resources
- Limited versions of subscription apps

Before downloading a free app, remember that "free" does not necessarily mean that no data is being collected. Read the privacy policy and understand what information the application requests.

Some free apps may use advertising, optional purchases, subscriptions, or other business models to support the service.

Are Mental Health Apps Safe?

Safety depends on the individual app.

One of the biggest mistakes users can make is assuming that every app in an app store has been clinically evaluated.

The APA notes that many consumer-facing wellness apps are not FDA regulated and are not subject to HIPAA. Digital therapeutics are a different category because they are intended to deliver clinically validated interventions for specific health conditions.

Privacy deserves particular attention because mental health information can be extremely personal.

Before using an app, check:

- What personal information does it collect?
- Does it collect health or mood information?
- Why does it need that information?
- Does it share data with third parties?
- How long is data retained?
- Can you delete your account and information?
- Is the privacy policy easy to understand?
- Does the company explain its security practices?

The APA has also warned about mental health apps that lack strong privacy protections, have insufficient evidence, or make exaggerated claims about what they can accomplish.

Are Mental Health Apps HIPAA Compliant?

This is one of the most misunderstood topics in digital mental health.

A common assumption is that every health-related application must automatically be HIPAA compliant. That is not necessarily the case.

The APA explains that many direct-to-consumer wellness apps are not covered by HIPAA, while regulated digital therapeutics used within healthcare can fall under different privacy and regulatory requirements.

Therefore, do not select an app solely because its marketing uses terms such as "secure," "private," or "health."

Read the actual privacy policy and determine how your information is collected, stored, used, and shared.

Are Mental Health Apps FDA Approved?

Again, the answer depends on the type of application.

A general meditation app does not need to be FDA approved simply because it promotes relaxation or mindfulness.

Digital therapeutics designed to diagnose, treat, or prevent specific medical conditions are different. The APA explains that these products may be regulated by the FDA as software medical devices.

It is also important to use accurate terminology. Some digital health products are FDA cleared, while others may have different regulatory classifications. Saying that every mental health app is "FDA approved" would therefore be misleading.

When an app makes a clinical claim, look for specific information about its regulatory status and evidence rather than relying only on promotional language.

How to Choose the Best Mental Health App

There is no single mental health app that works perfectly for everyone. Your starting point should be the problem you want to address.

For meditation

Look for guided sessions, breathing exercises, mindfulness programs, and content suitable for your experience level.

For anxiety

Look for evidence-informed approaches such as CBT exercises, relaxation techniques, mindfulness, and professional support when necessary.

For mood tracking

Choose an app that makes daily check-ins simple and allows you to review patterns over time.

For sleep

Look for sleep-focused content, relaxation exercises, sleep stories, and tools that encourage consistent bedtime habits.

For therapy

Focus on platforms that connect you with appropriately licensed professionals and clearly explain their services, pricing, privacy practices, and insurance options.

For specialized conditions

Look for applications specifically designed for the condition and investigate the clinical evidence supporting the product.

The APA recommends doing research beyond an app-store rating. Users should look for published research, professional involvement, and clear privacy policies before deciding whether a digital mental health product is appropriate for them.

Mental Health Apps and Online Therapy: What's the Difference?

A meditation app might teach you how to practice mindfulness. A mood tracker might help you recognize patterns. An online therapy platform can connect you with a licensed professional.

These are fundamentally different services.

A mental wellness app may be appropriate when you want to develop healthier routines or learn relaxation techniques.

Online therapy may be more appropriate when you want individualized professional support.

Neither option automatically replaces the other. Some people may use self-care tools between therapy sessions, while others may use wellness applications independently for everyday stress management.

Can Mental Health Apps Replace a Therapist?

For general wellness activities, an app can be a convenient addition to your routine. However, a wellness application should not automatically be considered a replacement for psychotherapy or psychiatric care.

A therapist can evaluate your individual situation, ask follow-up questions, recognize changes in symptoms, and adjust treatment according to your needs. A basic app generally cannot provide that same level of individualized clinical judgment.

The APA has also cautioned that consumer AI chatbots and wellness applications may lack adequate scientific validation, clinical oversight, and safety protocols.

For that reason, apps are generally best understood as tools that may support mental wellness rather than universal replacements for human care.

Mental Health Apps and AI

Artificial intelligence has become an increasingly visible part of mental wellness applications.

AI features may be used for journaling prompts, personalized recommendations, conversational support, mood reflection, or other forms of self-guided interaction.

These features can make applications feel more personalized, but users should be careful about treating AI as a therapist or medical professional.

The APA's current health advisory warns that many consumer-facing AI chatbots and AI-enabled wellness applications lack the rigorous testing, safety measures, and regulatory oversight necessary to provide clinical mental health treatment.

The same caution applies to personal information. Before sharing highly sensitive mental health information with an AI-powered app, understand what happens to the information after you submit it.

Mental Health Apps in the USA

The U.S. market includes a wide range of mental health and wellness applications, from consumer meditation apps to online therapy platforms and FDA-regulated digital therapeutics.

One important feature of the U.S. market is the role of insurance and licensed providers. Online therapy services may determine eligibility based on the user's insurance plan, location, and the provider's state license.

For example, Headspace currently offers online therapy to adults in the U.S., with insurance eligibility available through its enrollment process. The company states that therapy availability and cost can vary depending on factors such as location, age, and insurance coverage.

Talkspace similarly requires providers to be licensed in the state where the patient resides, which is an important consideration when using online therapy services.

The U.S. also has a growing category of regulated digital therapeutics. Unlike ordinary wellness applications, these products can deliver clinically validated interventions for specific conditions and may require an order or prescription.

Because the market contains such different types of products, consumers should always check what an app actually provides instead of assuming that every "mental health app" offers medical treatment.

Mental Health Apps for Teens and Young Adults

Young people are among the groups increasingly exposed to digital mental health tools.

Meditation, journaling, habit tracking, and self-care apps may provide accessible ways to encourage healthy routines. However, parents and young users should pay particular attention to privacy, age requirements, data collection, advertising, community features, and safety systems.

AI-based mental health tools require additional caution for younger users. The APA has called for stronger safeguards around AI technologies used for mental health, particularly for children, teenagers, and other vulnerable populations.

A young person experiencing significant anxiety, depression, self-harm thoughts, eating problems, trauma symptoms, or another serious concern should not be left to manage the situation through an app alone.

How to Use a Mental Health App Effectively

Downloading an app is only the first step. How you use it can make a major difference.

Start with one specific goal. Instead of trying every feature immediately, decide what you want the app to help with.

For example, you might use a meditation app for five minutes each morning, a mood tracker once a day, or a sleep exercise before bed.

Consistency is usually easier when the activity fits naturally into your schedule.

You should also avoid turning mental wellness into another source of pressure. If an app's streaks, reminders, notifications, or progress scores make you feel more anxious, change the settings or stop using those features.

Most importantly, use the information you collect as a way to understand yourself rather than judge yourself.

When You Should Seek Professional Help

Mental health apps can be useful, but there are situations where professional help should take priority.

Consider speaking with a qualified healthcare or mental health professional if emotional or psychological symptoms:

- Continue for an extended period
- Interfere with work or school
- Affect relationships

- Make everyday responsibilities difficult
- Significantly change your sleep or appetite
- Cause severe anxiety or panic
- Make you feel hopeless
- Lead to thoughts of self-harm or suicide

If you are in immediate danger or experiencing a mental health crisis in the United States, call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department. You can also call or text 988 for the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. The service is available free of charge and offers confidential support.

Frequently Asked Questions About Mental Health Apps

What is the best mental health app?

The right app depends on what you need. Meditation apps can be useful for mindfulness and relaxation, mood trackers can help identify patterns, self-care apps can support daily routines, and online therapy platforms can connect users with licensed professionals.

What is the best mental health app for anxiety?

Apps that provide mindfulness, breathing, relaxation, CBT-based exercises, or access to professional therapy may be useful depending on the situation. Persistent or severe anxiety should be discussed with a qualified professional.

What is the best mental health app for depression?

Mood tracking, journaling, self-care, and structured digital interventions can serve different purposes. Some prescription digital therapeutics are specifically designed for depression, but they should be used according to their authorized indications and professional guidance.

Are there free mental health apps?

Yes. Some mental health and wellness apps offer free versions or free resources. However, features may vary, and some apps use subscriptions or in-app purchases for advanced content.

Are mental health apps safe?

Safety varies considerably. Check an app's evidence, privacy policy, data-sharing practices, security information, professional involvement, and regulatory status before using it for sensitive information.

Are mental health apps covered by insurance?

Some online therapy and clinical mental health services may be covered by health insurance, but coverage depends on the provider, insurance plan, location, service, and eligibility. Wellness apps generally work differently from medical treatment services.

Are mental health apps HIPAA compliant?

Not all of them. Consumer wellness apps are not automatically covered by HIPAA. The APA distinguishes these apps from regulated digital therapeutics and healthcare services that operate under different regulatory and privacy requirements.

Can an app diagnose depression or anxiety?

A general wellness app should not be treated as a substitute for a professional diagnosis. Diagnosis requires appropriate assessment by a qualified healthcare professional.

Are AI mental health apps safe?

AI can be useful for certain wellness activities, but consumer AI tools have limitations. The APA warns that many AI chatbots and AI wellness applications do not have the scientific validation, safety protocols, or regulatory oversight expected of clinical mental health treatment.

What should I look for before downloading a mental health app?

Look at the app's purpose, evidence, professional involvement, privacy policy, security practices, pricing, age requirements, regulatory status, and user-data practices. Do not rely solely on an app-store rating.

Final Thoughts

The growing selection of mental health apps makes it easier to find digital tools for meditation, stress management, sleep, mood tracking, self-care, anxiety support, and online therapy. However, the large number of options also makes it more important to understand exactly what an app is designed to do.

Apps such as Headspace and Calm are useful examples of wellness platforms built around meditation, mindfulness, relaxation, sleep, and everyday mental wellness. Daylio and similar tools focus more heavily on mood tracking, while services such as BetterHelp and Talkspace are designed around access to professional therapy. Specialized tools such as PTSD Coach and NOCD focus on particular mental health concerns.

There is also an important difference between consumer wellness apps and digital therapeutics. Some prescription digital therapeutics are developed to deliver clinically validated interventions for specific conditions and may be regulated by the FDA.

Ultimately, the best mental health app is not necessarily the one with the highest download count or the largest number of features. It is the tool that matches your particular goal, is transparent about its limitations, handles personal information responsibly, and fits comfortably into your life.

If an app helps you develop a healthier routine, practice mindfulness, understand your moods, improve your sleep habits, or take the first step toward professional support, it can be a useful part of your mental wellness toolkit. At the same time, serious or persistent mental health concerns deserve appropriate professional attention rather than being managed entirely through a smartphone application.